Journal of Meaning-Centered Psychology
PUBLISHED BY THE INSTITUTE FOR MEANING-CENTERED PSYCHOLOGY

Volume 1 · Issue 1 · April 2026
pp. 14–17 · Open access · CC BY 4.0

METHODS ARTICLE

Measuring Meaning in Life

The Purpose in Life Test, the Meaning in Life Questionnaire, and LeBe/SoMe in Conceptual and Methodological Comparison

Samuel R. Ashford, Sora Pazer and Eleanor M. Whitcombe
Institute for Meaning-Centered Psychology

ABSTRACT

Empirical research on meaning in life is inseparably linked to the development of suitable measurement instruments. This methodological paper compares three families of instruments that are particularly widely used in research and practice: the Purpose in Life Test, developed within the tradition of logotherapy; the Meaning in Life Questionnaire with its distinction between presence of meaning and search for meaning; and the Sources of Meaning and Meaning in Life Questionnaire (SoMe) and its German counterpart LeBe, which additionally assess sources of meaning. The Existence Scale is considered as an instrument rooted in the existential-analytic tradition. The instruments are described with respect to their theoretical foundations, structure, construct delineation, and typical fields of application. The central focus is on construct validity: the paper discusses to what extent the instruments distinguish experienced meaning from related constructs such as well-being, depressive symptoms, or life satisfaction, and which facets of meaning each of them captures. Finally, recommendations for the selection of instruments in research, assessment, and evaluation are formulated, including orientation toward the research question, the combination of global and source-specific measures, and a cautious interpretation of sum scores in individual assessment.

Keywords: meaning in life · psychological assessment · construct validity · questionnaires · measurement

1 Introduction

A psychological construct can only be researched as well as it can be measured. This applies to meaning in life to a particular degree, because the term is used with very different meanings in everyday language, philosophy, and psychotherapy. The choice of a measurement instrument is therefore never merely a technical decision but always implies a theoretical commitment as to what is understood by meaning.

The present contribution presents selected, frequently used procedures in comparison. It does not aim at a complete overview but seeks to work out the conceptual differences between the instruments and to derive recommendations for practice from them. It is guided by an understanding of validity as a unitary concept relating to the interpretation of test scores (American Educational Research Association et al., 2014; Messick, 1995).

In addition, research on meaning in life relies to a high degree on self-report procedures. Alternative approaches such as qualitative interviews, narrative procedures, or everyday assessments with repeated brief surveys complement the methodological repertoire but are considered only peripherally in what follows.

2 The Purpose in Life Test

Crumbaugh and Maholick (1964) developed the Purpose in Life Test (PIL) in order to capture Frankl's concept of noogenic neurosis and the existential vacuum psychometrically. In its best-known form, the instrument consists of 20 statements answered on a seven-point scale, each with individually worded anchors; supplementary qualitative parts with sentence completions and a free essay are used less frequently in research. For decades, the PIL was the most frequently used meaning instrument, and it forms the basis of a large part of logotherapeutically oriented research.

At the same time, the PIL has been widely criticized. In an early analysis, Dyck (1987) pointed to conceptual and psychometric problems, in particular

the heterogeneity of item content and its overlap with constructs such as depressiveness and life satisfaction. Some items capture mood or zest for life rather than meaning in the narrower sense. This criticism concerns discriminant validity and is significant for the interpretation of associations with symptom measures. With the short form PIL-SF, Schulenberg et al. (2011) presented an economical four-item variant that focuses more closely on the core of the construct.

A further problem lies in the wording of some items, which implicitly contain value judgments, for instance with regard to life goals or attitudes toward death. Such formulations may be understood differently depending on culture and worldview. For the interpretation of group differences, measurement invariance must therefore be tested before means are compared between groups.

3 The Meaning in Life Questionnaire

Steger et al. (2006) developed the Meaning in Life Questionnaire (MLQ) with the explicit aim of overcoming weaknesses of earlier procedures. The instrument comprises ten items assigned to two subscales: the presence of meaning and the search for meaning. The authors placed particular emphasis on distinguishing the construct from related constructs and reported evidence of convergent and discriminant validity in their validation studies.

The strength of the MLQ lies in its brevity, its clear structure, and the conceptually significant separation of presence and search. One limitation is that the items are worded in comparatively global terms and provide no information about where a person derives meaning from or which facet of the experience of meaning is in the foreground. The distinction between coherence, purpose, and significance proposed by Martela and Steger (2016) is not represented in a differentiated way by the MLQ.

For the interpretation of the Search subscale, it is important that the search for meaning must not be understood per se as a deficit. Steger et al. (2006) conceptualized presence and search as relatively independent dimensions. Depending on the phase of life and the context, the search for meaning can be an expression of openness and development or of uncertainty and distress. It therefore becomes diagnostically informative only in combination with the degree of experienced meaning.

4 LeBe and SoMe: Experience of Meaning and Sources of Meaning

With the Questionnaire on Sources of Meaning and Meaning in Life (Fragebogen zu Lebensbedeutungen und Lebenssinn, LeBe), Schnell and Becker (2007) presented a procedure that goes beyond the global experience of meaning. In addition to scales on meaningfulness and crisis of meaning, the instrument assesses a larger number of sources of meaning, that is, sources from which people can derive meaning. These are assigned to superordinate dimensions ranging from vertical and horizontal self-transcendence through self-actualization and order to well-being and relatedness. The English-language version, SoMe, was described by Schnell (2009).

The particular achievement of this approach lies in the separation between the degree of the experience of meaning and its sources. This makes accessible research questions that cannot be investigated with global measures, for instance whether the experience of meaning depends more on the diversity or on the intensity of individual sources of meaning. In addition, the separate assessment of meaningfulness and crisis of meaning allows the identification of people who neither experience meaning nor suffer from its absence (Schnell, 2020). The greater length of the instrument must, however, be taken into account when planning studies and diagnostic assessments.

For practice, it should be emphasized that the source-related profile can offer starting points for counseling and therapy, for instance when it becomes apparent that a person's experience of meaning rests on very few sources. Such profiles should not, however, be read normatively: there is no composition of sources of meaning that is equally right for all people.

5 The Existence Scale

The Existence Scale (Existenzskala, ESK) by Längle et al. (2000) stems from the tradition of existential analysis. It does not primarily capture the experience of meaning but rather personal capacities that, according to the existential-analytic understanding, are prerequisites for a meaningful way of life: self-distancing, self-transcendence, freedom, and responsibility. It thereby operationalizes central concepts of Frankl's anthropology and is particularly suitable for research questions aimed at existential resources and their change in the therapeutic process.

For evaluation studies of logotherapeutic and existential-analytic interventions, the Existence Scale is of particular interest because it captures capacities

that, according to the underlying theory, are supposed to be fostered by treatment. It is therefore potentially suitable as a process measure. At the same time, it should be noted that the scale is closely tied to a particular theoretical model; its results can therefore be interpreted mainly within the framework of that model (Längle et al., 2000).

6 Construct Validity as the Guiding Question

Cronbach and Meehl (1955) already emphasized that construct validity cannot be demonstrated by a single coefficient but can only be made plausible within a nomological network. For the measurement of meaning in life, this means that instruments should not only be associated with well-being and mental health but should at the same time be distinguishable from these constructs. An instrument that largely captures the experience of meaning as the opposite of depressed mood is hardly suitable for testing the hypothesis that meaning acts as an independent protective factor.

The distinction from eudaimonic well-being is also significant. Ryff (1989) conceptualized purpose in life as one of several dimensions of psychological well-being. Anyone who assesses the experience of meaning and well-being simultaneously should therefore check whether the instruments used contain items with overlapping content. Otherwise, associations may be partly due to item overlap rather than to substantive relationships.

A further challenge concerns the distinction between state and trait aspects. The experience of meaning may be relatively stable over time but is also subject to situational fluctuations, as studies on its association with positive affect suggest (King et al., 2006). For measuring change in therapy and counseling, it must therefore be examined whether an instrument is sufficiently sensitive to change; for interpreting individual change, indices such as the standard error of measurement should be used.

7 Recommendations for Choosing an Instrument

Several recommendations can be derived from the comparison. First, the choice of an instrument should proceed from the research question: for economical assessments of the global experience of meaning, the MLQ is a good choice; for the investigation of sources of meaning and crises of meaning, the LeBe or SoMe; for the assessment of existential capacities, the Existence Scale. The PIL remains significant for comparability with older research but should be interpreted with awareness of its overlap with related constructs.

Second, in many cases the combination of a global measure with a source- or facet-related measure appears advisable. Third, restraint is called for in individual diagnostic assessment: questionnaire scores on meaning in life can supplement, but not replace, a clinical conversation about values, goals, and life circumstances. Finally, when using translated instruments, attention must be paid to validated language versions and to the appropriateness of the norms for the respective target group.

Finally, reports should state which version of an instrument, which response scale, and which scoring rules were used. In the case of the PIL in particular, different versions and translations exist, which makes the comparability of findings more difficult. Transparent information facilitates replications and meta-analytic integration and meets the requirements for comprehensible test use (American Educational Research Association et al., 2014).

References

American Educational Research Association, American Psychological Association, & National Council on Measurement in Education. (2014). Standards for educational and psychological testing. American Educational Research Association.

Cronbach, L. J., & Meehl, P. E. (1955). Construct validity in psychological tests. Psychological Bulletin, 52(4), 281–302.

Crumbaugh, J. C., & Maholick, L. T. (1964). An experimental study in existentialism: The psychometric approach to Frankl's concept of noogenic neurosis. Journal of Clinical Psychology, 20(2), 200–207.

Dyck, M. J. (1987). Assessing logotherapeutic constructs: Conceptual and psychometric status of the Purpose in Life and Seeking of Noetic Goals tests. Clinical Psychology Review, 7(4), 439–447.

King, L. A., Hicks, J. A., Krull, J. L., & Del Gaiso, A. K. (2006). Positive affect and the experience of meaning in life. Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 90(1), 179–196.

Längle, A., Orgler, C., & Kundi, M. (2000). Existenzskala (ESK). Beltz Test.

Martela, F., & Steger, M. F. (2016). The three meanings of meaning in life: Distinguishing coherence, purpose, and significance. The Journal of Positive Psychology, 11(5), 531–545.

Messick, S. (1995). Validity of psychological assessment: Validation of inferences from persons' responses and performances as scientific inquiry into score meaning. American Psychologist, 50(9), 741–749.

Ryff, C. D. (1989). Happiness is everything, or is it? Explorations on the meaning of psychological well-being. Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 57(6), 1069–1081.

Schnell, T. (2009). The Sources of Meaning and Meaning in Life Questionnaire (SoMe): Relations to demographics and well-being. The Journal of Positive Psychology, 4(6), 483–499.

Schnell, T. (2020). Psychologie des Lebenssinns (2. Aufl.). Springer.

Schnell, T., & Becker, P. (2007). Fragebogen zu Lebensbedeutungen und Lebenssinn (LeBe). Hogrefe.

Schulenberg, S. E., Schnetzer, L. W., & Buchanan, E. M. (2011). The Purpose in Life Test-Short Form: Development and psychometric support. Journal of Happiness Studies, 12(5), 861–876.

Steger, M. F., Frazier, P., Oishi, S., & Kaler, M. (2006). The Meaning in Life Questionnaire: Assessing the presence of and search for meaning in life. Journal of Counseling Psychology, 53(1), 80–93.

HOW TO CITE

Ashford, S. R., Pazer, S., & Whitcombe, E. M. (2026). Measuring Meaning in Life: The Purpose in Life Test, the Meaning in Life Questionnaire, and LeBe/SoMe in Conceptual and Methodological Comparison. Journal of Meaning-Centered Psychology, 1(1), 14–17.

LICENSE, CORRESPONDENCE AND USE OF AI

Published open access under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International license (CC BY 4.0). Correspondence: Editorial office, Journal of Meaning-Centered Psychology. This article was written with the assistance of generative AI and reviewed by the authors, who take full responsibility for its content.